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Some Details of the Journal of Jacob Roggeveen

Herbert von Saher,
Bloemendaal, the Netherlands

Every reader of *RNJ* probably knows that Jacob Roggeveen discovered Easter Island on Easter Day in April 1722, but few readers know more from the journal of Roggeveen. The editors of *RNJ* have asked me to write about some of the journal's details that may be of interest to the student of Rapa Nui. I will give attention to three aspects of the journey: 1) Why it was an extraordinary journey; 2) What happened during the days that Roggeveen's fleet was near Easter Island; and 3) How the whole expedition ended in disaster.

The expedition was extraordinary in two ways. In November of 1520, Magellan, a Portuguese in Spanish service, first entered the Pacific through the strait that still bears his name. Between that moment and roughly 1650, most of the oceans of the world were visited and mapped. After 1650, few great discovery-trips were made. Why did Roggeveen leave 71 years later in 1721? It was Jacob Roggeveen's father, Arend Roggeveen (a wine merchant with a hobby for geography and astronomy) who, in 1671, together with other merchants from Zeeland, made a plan to navigate the Pacific and, more specifically, to discover "Southland." Southland was supposed to be a continent lying east of New Zealand, perhaps of the size of Australia and in one of the few areas of the Pacific not yet mapped. In 1675 this plan was presented to the States General of the Netherlands along with a request for a Charter. In 1676 this Charter was granted, but Arend Roggeveen and his friends were unable to finance the expedition and it did not take place. Arend Roggeveen died in 1679.

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The Poike Ditch in Retrospect

By Carlyle S. Smith, Ph.D.

The nature, origin and function of the Poike Ditch has often received at least passing reference in the now voluminous published comments on Easter Island. First, I do not intend to get into the controversy over the legend, or myth, assigning it a role in a conflict between two groups of people known as the Hanau Eepe and the Hanau Momoko. My primary concern is whether or not the hand of man was involved in its form and function.

Routledge (1919:281, footnote) concludes that the ditch was the result of geological faulting, but attributes the mounds on the eastern edge to possible use as fortifications. The geologist Chubb (1933:33) must have viewed the entire feature from afar in 1925 because he terms it a "gully" and the reader is forced to assume that it is located at the base of an eroded cliff instead of at the top. Métraux (1940:72) and Lavachery (1933:346-347) pass it off as a natural feature in the terrain. This is typical of Métraux who also displayed his myopic view of any alteration of terrain by man in his inability to see terraces on the hill known as Maunga Auhepa at Anakena (Métraux 1940:96; Smith 1961:277).

In 1955, as a member of the Norwegian Archaeological Expedition, I conferred with my colleagues Ferdon, Mulloy, and Skjølsvold concerning mutual agreements on the excavation of sites based on our peculiar backgrounds and interests. They agreed that I should investigate Poike Ditch because I had an academic background in geology and had previously excavated eight "ditch and bank" features at archaeological sites in Coastal New York and the Great Plains of North America.

To introduce the subject, let me quote from my published report on my work at the ditch (Smith 1961b:385): "An undulating plain thickly strewn with masses of black lava and smaller fragments

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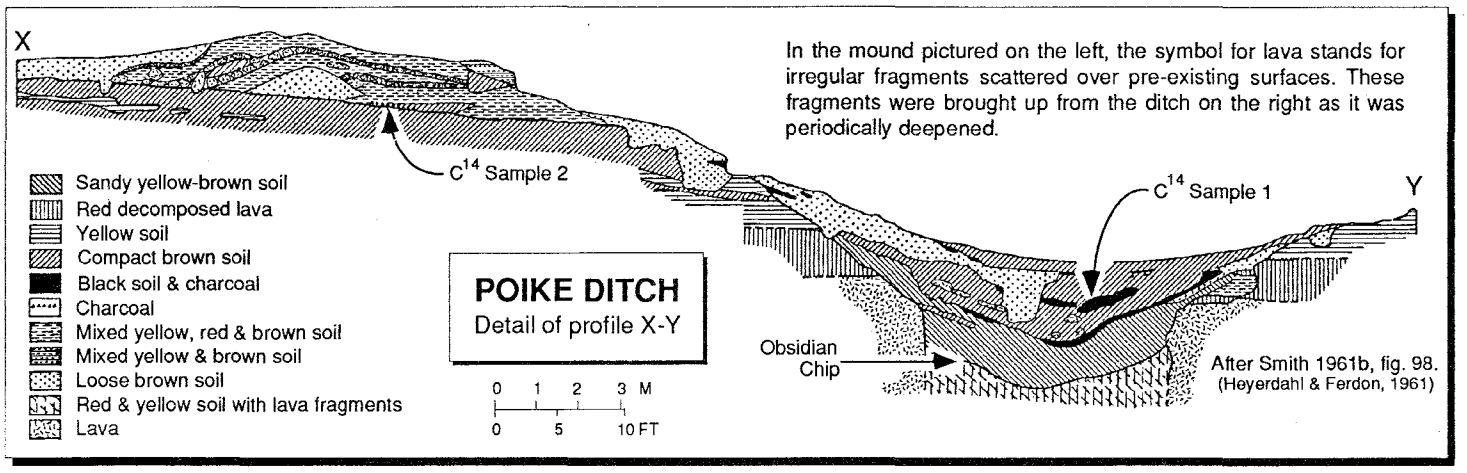

His son, Jacob, was born in 1659. He attended the Latin School and later went to the Academy of Saumur in France (the Protestant University). He got a doctor's degree in law. Applying for a job with the East India Company (V.O.C.), he was accepted and in 1706 he voyaged to Java as a passenger. In Batavia he became Council of Justice. He married there but his wife died before his return in 1715. It was after his return that his father's plan to discover Southland was revived by him. He applied to the West Indies Company (W.I.C.) which had the charter for the Pacific; they put three ships at his disposal for the discovery voyage. He left on 16 June 1721, 46 years after his father's first request was presented.

From the foregoing, it can be concluded that this voyage was a delayed exercise and that Jacob Roggeveen was quite different from the buccaneering type of early explorer for he was not only an intellectual, but when he left he was 62 years old, an age at which most early explorers were long dead or at least retired and sitting on their pieces of eight.

For the end of the story it should also be known that the States General of the Netherlands had chartered two companies to trade overseas and represent them: the "Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie" (V.O.C.) for the Eastern Hemisphere and the "West-Indische Compagnie" (W.I.C.) for the Western Hemisphere. The borderline of their territories at the other side of the world was the island of New Guinea. The V.O.C. was the first limited liability company on the basis of shares in the world; it was for two centuries the biggest company in the world and also the first multinational with establishments in South Africa, Mauritius, Sri Lanka, India, Burma, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, the Phillipines, China and Japan. It was tremendously powerful and it showed. The W.I.C. was never very successful and was more of an "underdog."

Easter Island

Roggeveen was instructed by the W.I.C. to proceed with due speed to the south Pacific, following more or less the course of two earlier Dutch explorers, Willem Cornelisz Schouten and Jacob Le Maire, and to discover Southland. On his way back he was—under no circumstance—to enter English ports or to inform anyone that he carried a cargo from Southland.

Roggeveen was commander over three ships: the *Arend* ("eagle"), Captain Jan Koster, with 110 men and 32 cannon; the *Thienhoven*, Captain Cornelis Bouman, with 80 men and 24 cannon; and the *Africaansche Galey*, Captain Roelof Rosendael, with 33 men and 14 cannon.

Roggeveen was quite different from the other early explorers: no unilateral decisions for him. For every important decision he met with his three captains in the "ship's council," and they pondered the alternatives together and then a decision was taken. These decisions were put down in written notes that all four signed, and these form an important part of the journal.

5 April 1722 • A tortoise was seen, then floating vegetation, and then birds. In the late afternoon the *Africaansche Galey* sighted land. It was decided to stop and await the next day. As this was Easter Day, Roggeveen decided to name the island Easter Island. There was great joy on the ships as the crews hoped that this island was along the coast of Southland.

6 April 1722 • The fleet cruised along the lee side of the island;as an easterly wind was reported, this must have been along the west coast. They saw smoke and concluded that it must be inhabited. A ship's council was held in which it was decided to go ashore in order to obtain fresh vegetables and fruit, "showing all friendliness to the inhabitants."

7 April 1722 • The weather turned bad with thunder, lightning, and heavy showers; the landing was postponed. But an Easter Islander came in a canoe to the *Thienhoven* and Captain Bouman brought this man to the *Arend*. Roggeveen, who sometimes shows a wonderful irony, describes this man as follows: "an Easter Islander, who was entirely naked, without the slightest cover in front of what modesty prevents to indicate more clearly." This man was greatly surprised to see this big ship with its high masts; he wanted to touch everything. He got the fright of his life when they held a mirror in front of him. He returned quite satisfied with sissors, the mirror and other small presents that he received.

The fleet came nearer to the coast and Roggeveen doubted that this island could be the "sandy, low island" that William Dampier had described in his earlier journal at about this position. What looked from a distance as sand appeared to be dried grass, hay or burnt growth giving an uncommonly meager impression. This means that already in 1722 Easter Island looked as it does today.

8 April 1722 • After breakfast, two sloops rowed to the coast. They had instructions not to go on land if the number of "Indians" was too large. This requires an explanation, also in relation to the fact that some books on Easter Island suggest that the trigger-happy Dutch fired at random at the population after some hats were stolen, starting that awful sequence of visitors that only brought murder and harm to Rapa Nui. On board their ships with the tremendous firepower of their cannons, the sailors were practically invulnerable to attack even by thousands of natives. But once they went on land, the situation became quite different: if hand to hand fighting broke out, a small band of sailors would not be able to maintain themselves against a very superior number of inhabitants. The possession of muskets, etc., does not help them anymore. This was always the great fear of the sailors who already had lost too many of their companions from scurvy and could not face more loss of life from fighting. A certain minimum is needed to man a ship and if this minimum is no longer there, then no one can return. The sailors always moved in closed squares so they should not become dispersed and thus more vulnerable.

The two returning sloops reported that on land the inhabitants were "very properly dressed" in materials of different colours and that they gave signs to come on land, which the sailors did not do. Some inhabitants were reported to be wearing silver plates on their ears and mother-of-pearl shells around their necks for adornment.

9 April 1722 • Many canoes came out to the Dutch ships. It was then that the obsession of the Easter Islanders with hats became clear, which Cook and La Perouse also commented on during their visits about 50 years later. The Easter Islanders stole hats and caps from the heads of sailors and immediately jumped overboard with them. Roggeveen saw that they were all excellent swimmers because many came swimming from land to the ships that were at anchor a quarter of a sea mile out from the coast. One Easter Islander

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climbed from his canoe through the porthole of the *Africaansche Galey* and escaped with a tablecloth. One gets the impression that the sailors saw this with some amusement and they certainly did not fire at these "souvenir hunters." (That was done 50 years later by a sailor of Captain Cook's fleet, who fired at an islander after having been robbed of his hat.) Captain Bouman could not understand what use they had for worn brooms, pieces of firewood and other trash.

10 April 1722 • Finally three sloops went to the coast with 134 armed men; 20 men stayed to protect the sloops. Remember that Roggeveen had left Holland with 223 men; without counting loss of life in the meantime, 134 men constituted 60‰ of their total strength. Climbing over the cliffs on the shore, the men began marching inland when suddenly some shots were heard at the back of the group. The commanders in front had not given orders for this and did not understand what had happened. Ten to twelve Easter Islanders were dead and more wounded. It appeared that one of the Islanders had tried to steal the gun of one of the sailors, while another tried to tear off a shirt and this started the skirmish in the rear. After recovering from the shock, the headman of the Islanders started negotiating with the Dutch and he gave orders to collect chickens, sweet potatoes, sugar cane and bananas. These orders were followed with due respect and curtesy. The Dutch paid "richly" in cloth that very much satisfied the Islanders.

Roggeveen describes the Easter Island clothing as "rags": a sort of thick reed, but he adds: "clean and hygienic." Apparently he did not know of the beaten tree-bark used in place of textiles. It was discovered that the "silver plates" worn on ears were, at short distance, not silver at all but the roots of a plant "like one would say in Holland of white coloured carrots" worn through the earlobes. These "carrots" are up to two inches in diameter causing the earlobes to extend. When the Islanders had to do jobs where the long earlobes were a nuisance, they hung the opening over the top edge of the ear, which made the Dutch laugh. This detailed description makes it clear that in 1722 there were many "long ears" on the island and either the war with the "short ears" (with only one long ear surviver) had not taken place or it never happened at all. Apart from the laughter about the ears, the visitors admired the Islanders' proportioned muscular bodies, the light colour of the skin (sometimes painted dark blue by members of the higher classes), their beautiful snow white teeth that were so strong they could crack nuts "as hard as peachstones" with them, and their long black hair rolled into a plait on top of the head, "just like the Chinese in Batavia." As regards their religion, Roggeveen notes that there was little time to study this, but he did see that the Islanders made fires in front of very high statues and they crouched on their heels, bringing their flat hands together and moving them up and down. Roggeveen was first greatly surprised that a people devoid of heavy wood to make tools from and thick rope could transport these heavy statues. Later this surprise diminished when they found out (and here they are quite wrong) that the statues were made of "clay or fat earth into which small stones had been pushed." They could not understand at all how the Islanders could cook without pottery, pans or barrels until they found out that it was done in holes in the ground with big stones that were preheated in fire. He gives a description of the houses with their wooden frames and low entrances and he is surprised by the ample (four feet wide) "terraces" around the houses made of big stones, flat and polished, and neatly put together (this makes one think of the "boulevards" of southern Nias, off the west coast of Sumatra).

Not much admiration was left for their canoes, however, which were narrow planks sewn together. As they lacked pitch to fill the seams, these canoes were very leaky so that the occupant had to spend half his time bailing. This clearly shows that in 1722, the scarcity of wood on the Island was already serious.

Roggeveen makes a few remarks on the feathers in the head-dresses of the Islanders, for it strikes him that he has seen so few birds on the island. He also commented on the body painting "in regular proportions so that one side of the body is in conformity with the other.'

The "King" of the Island had invited the group to visit the other side of the island where agriculture was practised and the fruit trees grew. But a strong northerly wind started, making their anchorage site on the northwest coast dangerous. Very few men were left on the ships, so it was decided not to prolong the stay on land. So they returned before the wind became too strong.

11 April 1722 • Strong winds and high seas cause the Thienhoven to break its anchor rope.

12 April 1722 • Strong winds continue and another anchor rope snaps and now the ships are in real danger of being driven onto the rocky coast. Roggeveen decides that this anchorage is too dangerous so the fleet hoists sail and moves off. They do some observation around Easter Island's shorelines and then move off to the west.

This ends a week near Easter Island and only one day ashore. Roggeveen took his order to proceed to Southland "as quickly as possible" quite literally; he was not interested in anthropological research and many after him would also find that the island's rocky coast with its strong changeable winds an unsafe place to lie at anchor.

Captain Bouman questioned the man who was responsible for the shooting and made it clear that he took this very ill of him. The man defended himself saying that not only had the Islanders tried to steal his gun but that he had been threatened with stones. This was not believed by witnesses who stated that in the great number of Islanders present, all had shown great friendliness toward them, and they considered him a "coward" who acted out of fear and nervousness. No punishment was reported.

The Final Humiliation • The fleet of Roggeveen had turned west from Easter Island. They touched several other small islands and in the Tuamotu archipelago they lost the *Africaansche Galey*, their smallest ship. They never found Southland. In the meantime, a great part of the crew was suffering from the dreaded scurvy and most of the food supply had seriously deteriorated. On 2 July 1722, another ship's council was held and it was decided not to return the way they had come, against prevailing winds and currents, but to continue west to the East Indies, an easier way and one in which they certainly would find fresh food supplies. They knew that this route would lead them through V.O.C. territory but, as they had no intention to trade there, they assumed that they would not violate the charter. This proved to be a disastrous mistake: as soon as Roggeveen had passed the island of New Guinea (the border of the charter territory) he was sighted by the V.O.C. On 8 September 1722 the V.O.C. representative on the island of Buru in the Moluccas reported to his superior on Ambon that he had contact with Jan Koster, captain of the Arent. On 19 September this superior sent a

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Roggeveen continued...

letter back, reprimanding his man for not have reported what sort of people "these tramps" were and where they came from. He asks: were they perhaps from Ostende? (a city in Belgium famous for its pirates). When he gets the correct answer, Roggeveen has already continued to Japara on the north coast of Java. There he gets into real trouble. He is not allowed to land and he may not buy food. Roggeveen writes an emotional appeal to the Governor General, telling how he has suffered 61 dead on the trip, how 12 men are suffering from scurvy, etc. Then he learns he may only get water and no fresh vegetables or fruit, essential for the survival of his men. He continues to Batavia, the headquarters of V.O.C. But there his ships are confiscated; the little cargo they have on board is sold and the whole crew including Roggeveen arrested on orders of the Governor General himself for "breach of priviledge." The V.O.C. wanted to show that it was not to be toyed with. On 25 September, the Governor General reported to his superiors, the famous "Council of Seventeen" in Amsterdam. The V.O.C. people, who also confiscated Roggeveen's journal, read in that document of the decision to return to the Netherlands via the Far East; this made the breach of the charter intentional and, therefore, even more serious. Towards the end of the year, Roggeveen and those of his crew who still survived were shipped back to the Netherlands as prisoners in a return fleet of the V.O.C. They arrived in July of 1723. When news of this reached Amsterdam, a terrible row broke out between the W.I.C. and the V.O.C.: this was a great period for lawyers. We do not have to go into all the details here, but finally the V.O.C.—although it had appealed on its charter it did not dare to risk a verdict in court—agreed to an out-of-court settlement. It kept the two confiscated ships remaining in Batavia, but it paid the W.I.C. a compensation of 120.000 guilders (about $60,000 at today's rate of exchange) which was, for that time, an enormous amount and certainly sufficient to build two new ships. Morever it paid all the wages still due to the crew.

Thus ended the voyage of discovery: Southland not found and a return in humiliation. This must have been a bitter disappointment for Roggeveen for he was a good commander and navigator and he executed his instructions as humanely as possible.

Let us end with one of his intelligent and nicely worded deliberations about Easter Island: "As the Spaniards or other people cannot have been moved to establish colonies of Indians in these faraway islands, one can only conclude that the Indians that live in these newly discovered islands have been here for generation after generation and are children of Adam, although the human mind is incapable of understanding by which means they have ever arrived here." This is the enigma with which all subsequent visitors to Easter Island have been confronted.